Conditional type 2

Goal: To talk about imaginary, unreal or improbable situations and their results with the second conditional (*If + past simple, would + base verb*), and to distinguish it from the first conditional.

The idea in two lines: Conditional type 2 is for dreams and hypotheses: things that are not true now or are very unlikely. The past simple after *if* does not mean past time; it shows that the situation is imaginary.

Type 1 vs Type 2

Type	If-clause	Main clause
1 – real possible future	If + present simple If I have time,	will + base verb I will visit you.
2 – unreal imaginary now	If + past simple If I had time,	would + base verb I would visit you.

Figure 1: Comparison table: type 1 is real and possible, type 2 is imaginary or improbable.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Structure:** *If + past simple, would + base verb.* Example: *If I had a lot of money, I would travel around the world.*
2. **Use:** an unreal situation in the present (*If I were a bird...*) or a very improbable one in the future (*If I won the lottery...*). It is the tense of dreams and wishes.
3. **Were for all persons:** with the verb *be*, we usually say *If I were / if he were*; *If I were you, I would...* is the classic way to give advice.
4. **Other modals in the result:** *could* (ability) and *might* (possibility) can replace *would*: *If I spoke Chinese, I could work in Beijing.*
5. **Short forms:** *would* → *'d*; *would not* → *wouldn't*. *I'd help you if I could.*
6. The two clauses can change order; use a comma only when the *if*-clause comes first.

7. **Meaning check:** type 2 implies the opposite is true now: *If I had a car...* = I don't have a car.

🟢 Examples

1. Complete: *If I ..... (be) the president, I ..... (build) more schools.* **Solution:** If I **were** the president, I **would build** more schools. **Explanation:** imaginary situation, so past simple (*were*) + *would*.
2. Choose type 1 or 2: *If Lina ..... (study) medicine, she ..... (become) a surgeon.* (She is a 4AM pupil, this is her real plan.) **Solution:** If Lina **studies** medicine, she **will become** a surgeon. **Explanation:** the plan is possible, so type 1.
3. Give advice: *Your friend never revises.* **Solution:** If I were you, I would revise every evening.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Putting *would* in the *if*-clause: *If I would have* ✕ → *If I had* ✓.
- Mixing the two types: *If I had time, I will* ✕ → *I would* ✓.
- Using the past participle instead of the past simple: *If I seen* ✕ → *If I saw* ✓.
- Thinking the past simple refers to the past: in type 2 it refers to now or the future.

🟡 Quick review

- Type 2 = unreal / improbable: If + past simple, would + base verb.
- *If I were you, I would...* = advice.
- could / might can replace would in the result.
- No *would* after *if*.
- Type 1 → will (real); type 2 → would (imaginary).

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